



Supplemental Manual for Premier Ultimate League Observers

The following is a guide for USAU-certified observers who are officiating games for the Premier Ultimate League. It is meant as a supplement to the [USA Ultimate Observer Manual](#) and aims to address best practices related to observing in the PUL. The primary sources for rules regarding gameplay in the PUL are the [USAU 2026–27 Official Rules of Ultimate](#) and the [2026 PUL Rules](#). In instances where the guidance of the PUL differs from that of the USAU resources, the guidance of the PUL Rules and Supplemental Manual should be given precedence.

Observer Uniforms and Equipment

With the exception of the jersey, the uniform for PUL observers is the same as that of observers for USAU games. Various official PUL observer jerseys have been created during several previous PUL seasons, and each team should have a supply of official PUL observer jerseys. Observers are nevertheless asked to bring their USAU observer jerseys to their games, as there may be instances when more observers are present for a game than there are available and properly fitting PUL jerseys. In those cases, uniformity is the priority, so whatever version of an officiating jersey that can be worn by all observers present should be chosen. The order of preference is as follows: 1) all observers in an official PUL observer jersey, 2) all observers in the green USAU jersey, 3) all observers in the orange USAU jersey, and 4) a mix of the available jerseys. For hats, some host teams may have offerings other than the black Discraft hats from USAU. Uniformity is the preference, but anything that doesn't clearly stand out is acceptable.

Observers are asked, if possible, to carry a whistle while observing games in the PUL. The PUL Rules indicate that the whistle may be used to assist with making active calls, but it is rarely actually needed for active observer calls. Although PUL games are played in stadiums with audiences that can grow fairly loud, most active calls can be communicated effectively with the voice alone. The whistle can therefore be saved for moments where verbal communication is insufficient for stopping play in a timely fashion. In practice, the most common use of the whistle is to signal that a timeout has been called from the sideline.

A coach or another designated member of each team may call a timeout from the sideline, and they are permitted to use a flag to help get the attention of the observers. Some home teams may provide a flag, but it is likely that observers may need to provide something for this purpose. Tying a piece of bright fabric into a knot can serve as a flag. Other versions of improvised flags could be fine, as well, so long as both teams agree to their use.

At least one observer for each game should carry a coin or two discs to the pregame meeting with the captains. Any coin will work, though a coin the size of a quarter or larger is recommended. Game



discs will be provided by the home team, but observers may need to ask the team staff for them. The game disc can be replaced if it goes far out of bounds, so it is useful to have extra discs stashed at various spots near the field. (If there are enough discs, they should be placed near each goal line and at midfield on both sidelines.) In the event that a disc goes far out of bounds, players will be encouraged to swap out the game disc for one of these replacement discs in accordance with USAU Rule 10.B.4.a. Observers should inspect the replacement discs prior to the game, so as to ensure that any disc swaps can occur quickly and without argument.

Observers may use whichever version of the USAU score card they prefer, but they should make note of a few differences regarding how penalties are marked: in the PUL, time violations result in an immediate yardage penalty (PUL Rules p. 4), so there is no need for the “warning” box that appears on scorecards USAU. The PUL also imposes a warning and then a penalty when someone attempts to call a timeout inappropriately (see the final bullet point under “Calling Timeouts” on PUL Rules p. 6), so observers may want to add a box for marking that a team has been warned about attempting an inappropriate timeout call.

Prior to the start of the game, it is recommended that observers review [this graphic](#) regarding the direction of the first pull of each quarter and overtime period. If necessary, observers may opt to print it out or add it to the back of a scorecard.

Pregame Considerations

It is recommended that observers for PUL games arrive at the field site at least 45 minutes prior to the scheduled game start. During that time, they should make sure they have all the equipment they need, including the equipment provided by the host team. Observers should inspect the field to make sure there are appropriate boundary markers, and that the markers are in the correct places. Unless changes need to be made for safety, the central zone of a PUL field is 80 yards in length, the end zones are 20 yards deep and the field width is 40 yards. It is useful to identify the location of the brick marks, which are 20 yards from the end zone lines; placing saucer cones near the sidelines can serve to mark the brick marks. Note that, if the game is being played on a field marked with football yardage lines, the bricks will be at the 30-yard lines, not on the 35-yard lines, as would be the case with a USAU field with a 70-yard central zone.

If the field boundaries are being marked with the official PUL pylons, be aware that the pylons have a tendency to fall over in windy conditions. Do your best to keep them upright during the course of the game. Like in USAU, but unlike in the UFA, boundary makers in the PUL *do* confer out-of-bounds status to the disc and to airborne players. If a pylon should fall over onto the field while also being in contact with the perimeter line, an airborne player who lands on the pylon would be rendered out of bounds, despite the fact that they might have landed close to 18 inches from the perimeter line. Our best remedy against this is to prevent the pylons from laying down on the field: if the wind keeps knocking them over, lay them down along the perimeter line or away from the field.



Prior to the start of each game, make sure that you have a working line of communication with your clock operator, that the clock operator understands the various rules regarding the ends of quarters in the PUL and that the clock operator has access to the PUL Clock Operator's Guide, which is located in Appendix A of this manual and is available as [a standalone file](#). In the event that you do not have access to audio communication with your clock operator, you should confer in advance about using hand signals to communicate about stopping the clock and adding time to the clock. Further information about correcting the clock using hand signals can be found in the "Clock Management" section on pp. 4–6 below.

The observers should speak with the head coach or coaches of both teams prior to the start of the game. During this meeting, the person designated to call timeouts from the sideline should be identified, and that person should be supplied with whatever timeout flag is agreed upon.

Uniform Policy for Players

The PUL no longer requires observers to enforce a uniform policy. Violations of the uniform policy will now be subject to fines assessed by the league to the team in violation, but observers will no longer be asked to prevent players who are in violation of the policy from taking the field. If you notice an obvious violation, you might want to remind a coach that uniform violations are subject to fines, but it will not be your responsibility to impose any sanction.

Pregame Ceremony and Coin Flip

Unlike many USAU games, most PUL games begin with an introductory ceremony. The exact format of the ceremony may vary depending on the choices made by the facility's gameday staff, but it will likely include player introductions and a coin flip, and the observers may need to be present for the entire ceremony. The process could begin up to 15 minutes before the scheduled game time, and it could last until close to the start of the game, so it is advised that all other preparations be completed by 15 minutes before game time.

The PUL rules call for a coin flip to decide starting possession and team positions, but some facilities prefer to let fans come onto the field to flip two discs. Either format is fine, and you should follow the wishes of the facility staff. Before you enter the field for the pregame ceremony, be sure that you have either a coin or the two discs for the fans. Depending on the timing of the ceremony, you may also need to bring along the game disc.

Whether you are using a coin or two discs, it is recommended that you ask the visiting team to make their selection ("heads" or "tails" if you are using a coin, "same" or "different" if you are using two discs) **BEFORE** you toss the coin or flip the discs. If you wait until after things are in the air and the visiting team doesn't make their call before things land, you'll have to repeat the process, which will



look strange to any onlookers. Once the teams have made their selections of position and possession, you may choose to signal their selections to the audience by having the captains of each team stand closer to the end zone their team will start from, handing the game disc to the captain of the first pulling team and mimicking a catching motion while standing with the first receiving team.

Clock Management

The presence of the game clock represents one of the most significant differences between USAU and PUL gameplay, and it is understood that many PUL observers may not have experience officiating with one. If it is new for you, it is worth mentally preparing yourself for the fact that you will need to glance up at the scoreboard or stadium clock before, during or shortly after certain moments in the game.

The most common events related to the starting and stopping of the game clock are the release of the pull and the act of scoring. Try to get into the habit of glancing at the clock immediately after the release of every pull and immediately after each score. During most of the game, the clock should start as soon as the pull is released; when you glance up at the clock, you should see that the clock is running. (Note: for many stadium clocks, the signal between the actual clock and the scoreboard can be weak, and scoreboard timer may appear to skip numbers or to pause on a number for several seconds. You may need to watch the scoreboard for a few seconds to determine if the clock actually hasn't started or if there is just a momentary issue with the signal.) If the clock hasn't started, try to track how much time passes from the release of the pull to the start of the clock. If it is more than five (5) seconds, ask the clock operator to subtract the amount of time that should have elapsed from the game clock at the next convenient moment (usually after a goal has occurred).

During the final two minutes of each timed period of play (i.e., Q1, Q2, Q3, Q4 and OT 1), the clock should **not** start on the release of the pull. The clock should instead **start on the release of the first legal pass after the pull**. (Note: this is new in 2026. The previous rule had the clock start when the disc was touched by an in-bounds offensive player or, in the case of an out-of-bounds pull, touched to the ground at the proper pivot spot. Players will now always need to attempt a pass before the clock will start during the final two minutes of each timed period of play.) As you are approaching the final two minutes of these periods, and before the first pull during these final two minutes, **remind your clock operator that the rules regarding the game clock are about the change**. During these final two minutes, when you glance up at the clock after the pull is released, you should see that it is not moving. If the clock does start incorrectly, stop play immediately and call for a re-pull. Give the receiving team up to 20 seconds to signal readiness and the pulling team up to 20 additional seconds to pull, but encourage the players to reset as quickly as they can. Make sure the clock has been corrected before allowing the re-pull.

If the disc ever goes out of bounds during the final two minutes of a timed period of play (i.e., Q1–4 and OT 1), the clock should only start when the disc is rendered “in play” by a ground touch at the appropriate spot on the field. If there is a stoppage of play for any reason during those final two minutes, the clock should only start after play has resumed with a check.



The clock should stop as soon as a goal has occurred, and not when the goal is signalled by the observers. For most of the game, one or two seconds won't matter too much, but the difference between the actual goal and the signal could matter toward the end of a time period. In those instances, it may be necessary for you to glance at the game clock at exactly the same time you make the "in-the-end-zone" signal, and before you make the "all clear" or "goal" signals. If there is any discrepancy between when the goal occurred and when the clock stopped, the correct time should be put on the clock, and both teams should be made aware of the change to the clock. If it becomes necessary to determine the precise second when a goal was scored, it should be considered to be the moment "an in-bounds player catches any legal pass in the end zone of attack, and retains possession of the disc throughout all ground contact related to the catch" (USAU Rule 13.A). If there is a duration to the "ground contact related to the catch," the very first moment of ground contact after possession has been gained should be considered the moment the goal was scored, unless the player subsequently bobbles the disc. If bobbling occurs, the first moment that is part of the eventual continuous possession should be considered the moment the goal was scored.

If you feel comfortable doing so, you may use the following hand signals to indicate to the clock operator when to start and stop the game clock. You may use this "wind the clock" signal



when the game clock should start, such as on the release of the pull (outside the final two minutes of Q1–4 and OT 1). You may use this "X" wave signal



when the game clock should stop, such as when a timeout is called.



For most games officiated under USAU rules, the “X” wave is used to signal any unspecified stoppage of play. However, since the “X” wave is used in the PUL to indicate to the clock operator that the game clock should be stopped, **observers should only use the “X” wave in cases where the game clock should be stopped.** Situations that require a clock stoppage and therefore call for an “X” wave are as follows: team timeouts, injury timeouts, technical timeouts, goals, a discussion of a call that lasts longer than 20 seconds, any stoppage during the final two minutes of Q1–4 or OT1 and the moment a disc becomes out of bounds in the final two minutes of Q1–4 and OT 1. (Note: although an out-of-bounds turnover during the final two minutes of Q1–4 or OT1 is not a stoppage of play, it does result in a stoppage of the clock. If you chose to use the “X” wave in such an instance as a signal to the clock operator, try to direct the signal away from the players, so as to avoid causing an inadvertent stoppage of play.)

If you notice a moment that the clock was running when it should have been stopped, or the clock was stopped when it should have been running, make note of how much time should be added or subtracted from the game clock. You shouldn’t worry about a second or two in most instances, but a discrepancy of five seconds or more is worth trying to fix, whether during the next convenient stoppage or, if possible, while play is still ongoing. You should only stop active play to correct the clock during end-or-quarter situations where you believe the offense would prefer to sacrifice their offensive flow in order to have the time corrected. In the best case scenario, observers are connected via audio to the clock operator, and the game clock can be corrected without need of a stoppage. In instances where no audio connection is available and the clock needs to be corrected during a stoppage, the “push up” hand signal



can be used to indicate that the game clock needs to be adjusted. After make this signal, the observer should say, “please reset the game clock to X minutes, X seconds,” indicating with both hands what number of minutes and what number of seconds the clock should read.

The “V” Hand Signal

For the 2026-27 Rules, USAU has adopted the following hand signal for general violations: “Arms straight, upward at a 45 degree angle, hands open, forming a ‘V’ with your arms” (*USAU 2026-27 Official Rules of Ultimate*, Appendix D). If a violation that lacks a specific hand signal is called, or if an observer determines at the beginning of a stoppage *that* a violation has been called but cannot immediately determine *which* violation has been called, the “V” signal should be used. (In the latter case, the specific signal should be given once the nature of the call has been determined.) However, in



situations where a specific hand signal does exist for a violation, and the nature of the called violation can be determined reasonably quickly, only the hand signal specific to the particular violation should be used.

Remember that stoppages can occur for reasons other than the call of a violation, so be careful not to give the “V” signal on every stoppage. A single raised hand above the head is still the appropriate signal for indicating that an as-yet-undetermined play-halting call has been made, and it remains the best way to signal a stoppage in most cases. In PUL games, the “X” wave signal is still reserved for signalling to the clock operator that the game clock should be stopped. Likely the most common call that will merit the use of the “V” signal is when a player begins to move prior to the checking-in of a dead disc.

If you ever use the “V” signal, be sure to form it clearly, as a lazily signalled “V” can easily be mistaken for a signal of “Pick” or “Goal”: there should be absolutely no bending at the elbows, and the angle of the arms should be clearly more outward than during the signaling of a goal. (The USAU guidance is unspecific about the orientation of the palms, but, for the PUL, the palms should face upward.) In practice, it is unlikely that observers will need to employ this hand signal very often, as most violations that need to be communicated to the sidelines and to viewers have specific hand signals. It is possible, however, that players might use the signal fairly often. In the event that players show the “V” signal in an indistinct and unclear manner (e.g., with a bend at the elbows), please be sure to echo the “V” signal in a way that clarifies the intended signal for onlookers.

Team Timeouts

When a timeout is called, the game clock should stop. Observers should call out “timeout” while using the “X” wave to signal that the clock should stop, and they should then make the “T” signal for the timeout. While forming the “T,” it is advisable to look at the game clock, so as to make sure that it is stopped at the correct time. If players don’t immediately react to the verbal “timeout” call, the whistle should be used to stop play. If time needs to be added to the clock, that can be done during the timeout.

The duration of a team **timeout in the PUL is 50 seconds**. Previous versions of the PUL Rules included some ambiguous language about whether a timeout should last 50 or 70 seconds, but *that has now been clarified*: for timeouts taken during active play, the offense must be set by the 50-second mark, and the defense must be set by the 70-second mark. It has also been clarified that timeouts taken between points should add 50 seconds to the between-point timings.

Team timeouts in the PUL reset the stall count, so observers don’t need to gather information about the stall count from the players. Both teams may substitute as many players as they like during the timeout, including the thrower. Each team has two timeouts per half and one timeout for each overtime period. Although team timeouts cannot be taken after the game clock has expired during any timed period of play, timeouts may be taken during OT 2.

Unlike in USAU, timeouts **can be called from the sideline during active gameplay**. Each team may



have one designated timeout caller (usually the head coach), who should be identified by the observers before the game. Also unlike in USAU, a timeout called while a thrower is in possession of the disc resets the stall count, so timeout calls from the sideline are often called in high-stall situations. If the stall count is getting high, it is advisable to keep an eye on the sideline, as it might fall to the observers to determine whether a timeout was called before or after a stall has occurred.

That having been said, it is normally the case the observers will have their eyes trained on the field during regular play, and they are often among the last people on the field to know that a timeout has been called from the sideline. The PUL rules state that the designated sideline caller “must get the attention of an Observer to call the timeout” (p. 6), but this should be taken with a grain of salt. Unlike in the UFA or other refereed sports, the players on the field won’t keep playing until they hear a whistle; instead, they will stop playing as soon as they think the stoppage should be taking effect, regardless of whether or not the observers have acknowledged the timeout. In that case, the moment that players on both teams agree the timeout began can be taken as the moment the stoppage began, and the observers can apply their acknowledgment retroactively to that moment. If necessary, observers may quickly consult the players and the designated sideline caller to determine the correct moment, but the observers should signal the final determination clearly and confidently.

Since whistles are not being used to signal the exact start and stop of play, determining the exact moment a timeout called from the sideline has come into effect is not an exact science. Try to be fair-minded, listen to the players and coaches, and try to apply the same standards throughout the game. There may be moments when it is difficult to determine whether or not a timeout was called before a stall or a throwaway. **When in doubt, err on the side of saying that the designated sideline caller successfully called the timeout before the turnover.**

If the offense stops play by calling a timeout inappropriately (i.e., if they have none to call, if someone other than the designated sideline caller attempts to call a timeout from the sideline, or if someone attempts to call a timeout after time has expired in any timed period of play), play should briefly stop. The observer should stop the clock with an “X” wave, then make the “T” signal for the timeout, then make three wipe away signals, as if for a retracted call. The observer should explain that a warning has been given for an improperly attempted timeout, and play should resume with a check. When the disc is checked, the observer should give the “wind the clock” signal to indicate the restart of the game clock. In the event that it is a team’s second such inappropriate timeout infraction, it is a turnover. The procedure is the same, but the disc will be on the ground when play resumes with a check.

In the unlikely event that a member of the *defense* manages to stop play by attempting to call timeout from the sideline, it should be treated as an inappropriate timeout committed by the defense, as this is a person not designated to call timeouts for the team in possession. The first such instance should result in a warning for an improperly attempted timeout. Any such instance that results in an interruption of the flow of play for the offense should result in a Team Misconduct Foul (blue card). If it were to be deemed intentional, a yellow card would be warranted.

A team timeout can only be called from the sideline when the disc is in possession of the thrower *or* when a turnover has just occurred, the team calling the timeout is about to take possession of the disc and the disc has either stopped moving or become out of bounds (i.e., gained out-of-bounds status). If



an in-bounds disc is rolling on the field in the in-bounds area and the coach attempts to call a timeout from the sideline, wait to grant the timeout and stop the clock until the disc has stopped moving, been picked up or rolled out of bounds. If time expires before one of those things has happened, play cannot be stopped, so the timeout cannot be granted.

Injury and Technical Timeouts

As with team timeouts, the game clock should stop for any injury timeouts and technical timeouts. Observers should use the “X” wave to signal to that the clock should stop, and they should glance at the clock to make sure it does stop. The clock should resume after the check, and the observers should give the “wind the clock” signal.

Heat Timeouts

In the event that excessive heat should pose a risk to player and observer safety, extra breaks should be added between points. Players and observers should be encouraged to seek shade and hydration during the breaks. For moderately high levels of heat (i.e., a heat index of 85 or above but below 90), a two-minute break can be added after the first goal scored following the six-minute mark in each quarter. For high levels of heat (i.e., a heat index of 90 or above), two two-minute breaks can be added to each quarter, the first after the four-minute mark, the second after the eight-minute mark. A reasonable number of additional breaks and/or breaks of greater length can be taken as deemed appropriate, and plans for heat timeouts should be discussed with the health and safety staff and with the teams prior to the start of the game. The signal for the heat timeout is the same as that for an injury/official’s timeout.

Time Between Points and Time Violations

After a goal, the receiving team has 50 seconds to be set on the line and to signal readiness, and the pulling team has 70 seconds to release the pull. (This is in contrast to the 50-to-set, 60-to-signal, 80-to-pull timings in USAU.) Unlike in USAU, there is no warning given to a team that exceeds these time limits. Rather, a Time Violation should be issued immediately: in lieu of a pull, play will start with the disc at either midfield or the reverse brick mark, depending on which team was issued the Time Violation penalty. Observers should still give clear warnings of the time remaining before the time limits, though, and penalties should only be occurring in the very rare circumstances that warnings and countdowns are being completely ignored or a last-second player substitution occurs.

The coaches of the receiving team must begin to leave the field at the 50-second mark, and all coaches should be off the field at the time the pull is released. As long as they are making their way toward the



sideline at a reasonable pace, and as long as they are at least close to the sideline at the time the pull goes up, we shouldn't be looking to issue a Time Violation. The point of these timing rules is to keep the game moving quickly, so be reasonable about enforcing Time Violations, and look to enforce them only in the service of ensuring that the game moves along smoothly.

Ends of Time Periods

As the game clock is nearing the end of each timed period of play, the fans will likely count down the final 10 seconds, and a buzzer may sound when the clock has reached 0:00.00. At that point, play will continue until the team who had possession (or was gaining possession as the result of a turnover) at 0:00.00 either scores or commits a turnover, so be careful not to signal any stoppages when you hear a buzzer. If a Callahan occurs during this time, the goal is awarded to the defense. You should continue to observe as usual until a turnover has occurred, and then you may signal the end of the quarter with an "X" wave.

It is possible for a buzzer to be out of sync with the game clock, and it sometimes happens that a stadium clock will display 0:00 when there is still somewhere between 0:00.01 and 0:00.99 remaining on the clock. It will be the responsibility of the observers to determine which team was in possession when time expired, so it is important to keep an eye on the clock as it is counting down and to keep an internal count of when the clock should reach 0:00.00. In the event that the stadium clock reaches 0:00 before your internal clock reaches 0:00.00, or in the event that the buzzer sounds either before or after your internal clock reaches 0:00.00, your determination of which team had possession when time expired should be treated as an active observer call. That is, the judgment you make based on your internal clock will be official, unless a player or coach overrules you to their detriment.

Note: Q4 and OT 1 no longer end immediately when the clock expires. That is, there is no longer a buzzer beater in the PUL.

Time Between Periods

The time between Q1 and Q2, as well as that between Q3 and Q4, is 2 minutes and 30 seconds. Halftime is 10 minutes long. In the event of an overtime, there should be five minutes from the final buzzer till the beginning of OT 1, with the overtime coin flip occurring during those five minutes. If the game goes to OT 2, there is no extra time: teams should be following the between-point timings of 50 and 70 seconds, though observers should be reasonable in encouraging players to get to their positions. (We wouldn't want an OT 2 to start with a Time Violation penalty.) For the time between the quarters, we should ideally have the receiving team set on the line at the moment the allotted time has elapsed, and not 50 seconds after that time. In practice, host facilities may have activities scheduled for the time between quarters, and those activities may run long. If that is the case, we need to let the activities run their course. It can be difficult in these cases to provide the teams with accurate warnings as to the time remaining in the break, and we should give teams a reasonable amount of



warning time, even if it means extending the break slightly. The first pull of a time period should not be allowed to take place before the game clock reads the correct time for the duration of the time period, namely 12:00 for Q1–4 and 4:00 for OT 1.

The Pre-stall

The pre-stall is the same in the PUL as in USAU. *There was previously a reference to a 10-second pre-stall for a disc that has come to rest in the end zone, but that has been removed.*

If a team wishes to attempt an “onside pull” (i.e., the pulling team drops the disc in their end zone or just in front of their end zone, rather than throwing the disc a more significant distance), observers should only begin the pre-stall after it has been made clear to the receiving team that a particular throw is intended to count as the pull. If an onside pull occurs, point to the disc and say, “this is the pull,” give the “wind the clock” signal, then signal and commence the pre-stall. If the receiving team still appears not to have understood the situation, delay your internal pre-stall count until it’s clear that they do understand and are reacting to the situation. If players attempt to count the pre-stall themselves, politely inform them that the official reading of the PUL Rules holds that, so long as observers are present at a game, only observers may count the pre-stall.

Replacing Discs

We want gameplay in the PUL to move quickly, and the paragraph at the top of p. 9 of the PUL Rules instructs the players to “swap in a replacement game disc” when doing so would save time. Several identical discs should be available for each game, and observers should inspect them for suitability prior to the game. It is suggested that you stash any extra game discs near the end zone lines, either hidden under an object (e.g., a pop-up banner) or far enough away from the field that they aren’t mistaken for the disc that was previously in use. If you believe you will be able to place a replacement disc in the correct spot before a player would be able to retrieve the game disc, signal to the offense and the defense that you are doing so. Once the disc is placed, you can give the thrower a shorter pre-stall than is normally appropriate for an out-of-bounds disc: unless the thrower has already run after the disc, a 10-second pre-stall is usually appropriate. If the thrower manages to grab one of the replacement discs before you have done so, *make sure it is clear to the defense that this is happening*. It is ultimately the responsibility of the thrower to ask a player on the defense if the new disc is acceptable in accordance with USAU Rule 10.B.4.a, but observers can help expedite that process by making clear that one of the pre-approved game discs is being swapped in. If it appears that the defense is being caught off guard by the change of disc, make sure to announce, “you have to ask the defense if the change of discs is OK.” If a throw goes off without acknowledgment, it will be up to the defense to call the violation.



The “Up” and “Down” Calls

Unlike in most USAU games, “up” and “down” are active observer calls. Players will expect you to make these call loudly, confidently and quickly whenever a disc has come within a few inches of the ground. It often helps to repeat the call loudly several times, and you may choose to add some words (e.g., “The disc was up, the disc was up!”). When you point your finger up or down for the signal, raise your hand above shoulder level and repeat the signal emphatically with a larger movement of your arm. The goal is to prevent any inappropriate slowing or stopping of play, as well as to make the call clear to the fans in the stands, so try to make the signals obvious enough that everyone in the stadium can quickly tell what the call is.

In an ideal world, the observers will always be positioned with a perfect line of sight between all the players on the field, and they will have a great view for every up/down call in the game. In reality, there are often several players between an observer and the disc, and observers may find their line of sight completely obstructed. If you cannot make a confident call for a disc that seemed close to the ground, do not make a call, and do not stop play to ask the players to make a call. If there is any significant question about whether a disc was up or down, and if the observers do not give a signal, the players will almost certainly talk about it on the field. This may take the form of a slight hesitation in the flow of play, or it may result in a full stoppage. If it appears that an actual stoppage is occurring, quickly inform the players that the observers’ views were obstructed and that the player on the field with best perspective should make the call. If there is no agreement, the disc should be sent back to the thrower. In order to communicate the call to onlookers, point an extended index finger alternately up and down several times, so as to signal that there is a discussion of an “up/down” call, and then make the “contest” signal.

Resolving Foul Calls

When a players makes a foul call, the game clock will continue to run. If play has not resumed within 20 seconds of the call, the clock operator will stop the game clock, and the clock will only resume once play has restarted with a check. Try to get into the habit of glancing at the game clock while you are giving the initial “foul” signal. As you are listening to the players discussing the call, keep an eye out for when the clock has run off 20 seconds. Once it has, give the “X” wave to signal that the clock should stop, and approach the players to see if they need assistance in resolving the call. If the players ask for your input before the 20 seconds has elapsed, you might find yourself too preoccupied to give the “X” wave at the appropriate time.

Immediate Referral

As with USAU, most calls are initiated by the players. Under USAU procedures, observers only offer rulings on calls if at least one of the players requests a resolution. In the PUL, there are four types of



calls that, when contested by the players, will automatically go to the observers of a ruling: travels, picks, stalls and marking violations. The PUL Rules ask observers to rule on these contested calls immediately. If you understand the situation and are able rule immediately, you may do so. If you do, players may be surprised by the brusqueness of your intervention, so it helps to preface your ruling by briefly reminding them of the existence of this rule. You might say something like, “because the PUL has asked observers to rule immediately on any contested stall calls, I am intervening now and ruling that this was a stall.” If the players seem well-acquainted with the procedure, you can skip the preface.

Although we are asked to rule “immediately,” in practice, you may need to ask some quick questions before you are able to offer a proper ruling. If a pick is called and a throw occurs, you will need to determine whether or not the player making the call is claiming that the pick affected the outcome of the play. If the player is claiming that it did affect the outcome of the play, you will need to rule on both whether or not it was a pick and whether or not it affected the outcome of the play. Try to get used to asking follow-up questions right away, so that the ultimate resolution can be reached as quickly as possible.

Misconduct System

The Misconduct System of the PUL is identical to that of USAU with the exception of two issues. The first is that an ejection can only occur in the PUL after the observers have convened and agreed unanimously that the ejection is warranted. (This is the case both for ejections resulting from a second yellow card and for those resulting from a red card.) If there is disagreement from the players or coaches about the merit of the ejection, the observers must convene with the spirit captains at the conclusion of the current half of play—either at halftime or after the conclusion of the game—and discuss the merits of the ejection. If the observers and spirit captains (which the PUL refers to as Team Ambassadors) unanimously agree to overturn the ejection, they may do so.

The second difference is new in 2026: whenever a yellow card is issued for a Dangerous Play, a yardage penalty will be assessed, even if the Dangerous Play represents the first or second instance of misconduct committed by a particular team during the game. (A full description is located on p. 16 of the PUL Rules under the heading 7.H.) In the event that the Dangerous Play is the first or second instance, the penalty will be to move the disc or the proper pivot spot 10 yards in the direction that is detrimental to the team whose player was issued the yellow card. If moving the disc or pivot would place it in the end zone of attack or behind the back end zone line, the disc is only moved half the distance to the front end zone line or half the distance to the back end zone line. If it is moved half the distance to the front end zone line, it will also be centered along the width of the field. If there are two offsetting Dangerous Plays on the same play, the yardage penalties will cancel out. If there are two Dangerous Plays committed by the same team, the penalties do not stack—it would just be one instance of 10 yards, and not 20 total yards. In the event that a yellow card for Dangerous Play is assessed on a play that results in a score, the 10-yard penalty will be assessed on the pull: both the pulling and receiving teams will set up 10 yards in front of or behind the front end zone line, as appropriate. (Note that this differs from the procedure for a Team Misconduct Penalty assessed between points, which is described in C3.C.6.a. of the USAU Rules, and for which the pull does not occur.)



The 10-yard penalty only applies to yellow cards issued because of Dangerous Plays, and not to yellow cards issued for other types of misconduct. Moreover, whenever a team has accrued a sufficient number of blue cards to warrant the Team Misconduct Penalty as described in C3.C of Appendix C of the USAU Rules, that penalty will apply instead of the 10-yard penalty. (That is, the disc or pivot will be moved to the brick or reverse brick marks, and it won't then be moved an additional 10 yards.) The idea is that some penalty should always be given for a Dangerous Play, even if a team hasn't yet reached the number of violations required for a Team Misconduct Penalty.

Restarting play after assessing the 10-yard penalty is basically the same as it would be for assessing a Team Misconduct Penalty: the offense has 30 seconds to set up wherever they like, with the disc or pivot at the correct spot, and the defense has 20 seconds to set up in response. If the defense received the yellow card, the stall count resets to one. If the offense received the yellow card, the stall count advances to count reached plus one, or nine if over eight. (This guidance is slightly at variance with the procedures for the Team Misconduct Penalty described in USAU C3.C.4.a., which indicates that the stall count should reset to one in the case that the offense commits the Dangerous Play and the disc is moved to the reverse brick mark. When applying the 10-yard penalty for a Dangerous Play committed by the offense, the stall count should *not* reset to one.) Play resumes with a check. It is likely that any discussion will have already lasted 20 seconds before the yellow card is issued; however, if there is a very quick uncontested Dangerous Play call that is agreed to before the clock has stopped at the 20-second mark, use the "X" wave to stop the clock before issuing the card and allowing the teams to move for the 10-yard penalty.

In any instance where a yellow card or a red card is issued, we request that observers send an email to PULObservers@gmail.com with a description of the event that drew the card, the number of the player to whom the card was issued and the approximate time of game when the card was issued.



Appendix A: PUL Clock Operator's Guide

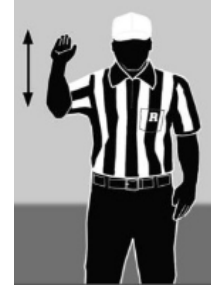
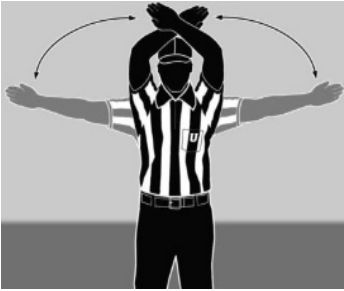
Please arrive at the booth at least 30 minutes before each game, so that a line of communication can be established with the observers, and any necessary practice can be conducted.

Observer Signals:

“X” wave = stop the clock

arm circle = start the clock

“push up,” followed by number =
reset clock to X minutes, X seconds



During the *first* 10 minutes of Q1–Q4 and the *first* 2 minutes of OT 1

The clock starts on:

- the release of the pull
- the check to resume play, following a stoppage of play that stops the clock

The clock stops on:

- the scoring of a goal, when the observers first signal “in” (i.e., when the observers point toward the end zone, and before they raise both arms skyward)
- any timeout, whether a team timeout, injury timeout or technical timeout
- a foul call that takes longer than 20 seconds to resolve (let run for 20, then stop)

During the *final* 2 minutes of Q1-4 and OT 1

The clock starts on:

- the release of the first legal pass other than the pull (*note: even if one of the following two conditions are met, wait for the release of the first pass*)
- the touch of the disc to the ground by the thrower, after a disc has been brought back onto the playing field from the out-of-bounds area (*note: if the thrower fails to touch the disc to the ground, start the clock when it is clear that the thrower is actively playing*)
- the check to make the disc live following a stoppage of play (even if the disc still must be advanced to the proper pivot spot before a throw may be attempted)

The clock stops on:

- the scoring of a goal
- a disc's first becoming out of bounds (*note: a disc becomes out of bounds when it touches an out-of-bounds offensive player, is caught by an out-of-bounds player or touches the out-of-bounds area, and not when it is simply in the air above the out-of-bounds area*)
- any play-halting call, timeout or other stoppage of play (*note: a call that does not stop play, such as a call of “travel” where no pass is made, does not stop the clock*)

**Duration of Time Periods and Breaks:**

Quarters 1-4:	12 minutes
OT 1:	4 minutes
OT 2:	untimed
Break between Q1 and Q2:	2 minutes and 30 seconds
Break between Q2 and Q3 (halftime):	10 minutes
Break between Q3 and Q4:	2 minutes and 30 seconds
Break between Q4 and OT 1:	5 minutes
Break between OT 1 and OT 2:	regular between-point timings, monitored by the observers

Note: If the time remaining in a break is being displayed on the official clock, please try to have the duration of the next time period displayed as quickly as possible after the break has ended. The observers will only allow the pull to take place after the clock has been set to 12:00 (for Q1-4) or 4:00 (for OT 1). In some stadiums, it may be easiest to begin resetting the clock when there are still 10 or 20 seconds remaining in the break period, so that the 12 or 4 minutes can be displayed as quickly as possible.

Timeouts per Team

First half of game (Q1-2):	2 Timeouts per team
Second half of game (Q3-4):	2 Timeouts per team
OT 1:	1 Timeout per team
OT 2:	1 Timeout per team



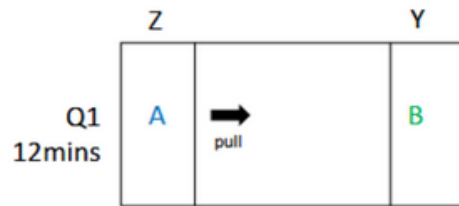
Appendix B: Key Differences between USAU and PUL Rules

	PUL	USAU
Game format, period timings, and game end	Four 12-minute quarters, plus one or two possible overtime periods; game ends after the final possession of Q4 or OT 1, or with the first score during OT 2	Two halves, limited by time caps; game ends when a team reaches the game total
Position and possession	Review this graphic	The team that starts the first half on offense starts the second half on defense; the teams swap their starting positions from one half to the other
Field dimensions	80 yards x 40 yards, plus 20-yard end zones	70 yards x 40 yards, plus 20-yard end zones
Time Violations	Immediate penalty	One warning, then penalty
Time between score and pull	50 seconds for offense to be set and signal, 70 for the pull	50 seconds for offense to be set, 60 to signal, 80 for the pull
Timeouts	Resets stall count; all players may substitute; 50 seconds till offense must freeze; may be called by designated person on the sideline, in certain cases before the disc is in possession	Stall count remains; substitutions only for injured players; 70 seconds till offense must freeze; may be called only by the thrower in possession of the disc
“X” wave	“Stop the clock”	“Stop play”
Ejections	Reviewable during halftime	
Overruling active observer calls	Players on the field and any coaches may overrule an observer call if it is to their team’s detriment to do so	Players may overrule an observer call if it is to their team’s detriment to do so
Yellow Card for Dangerous Play	Results in a yardage penalty even if it represents the first card given to a team; if it is one of the first two cards given to a team, it results in a 10-yard penalty, otherwise the USAU Team Misconduct Penalty applies	May result in the issuance of a yardage penalty in the form of a Team Misconduct Penalty, but only if it represents the third blue or yellow card issued to a team



Appendix C: PUL Game Progression

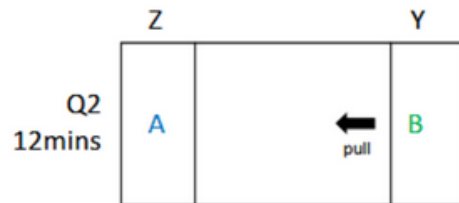
Coin flip.



Period ends on

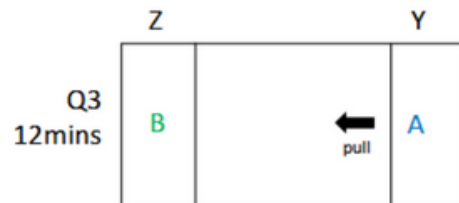
Last possession

(Additional stoppage criteria during the final 2 minutes)



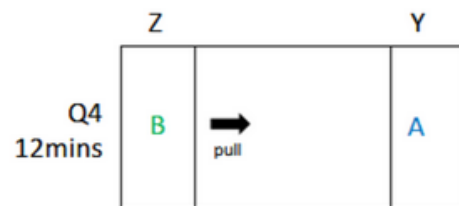
Last possession

(Additional stoppage criteria during the final 2 minutes)



Last possession

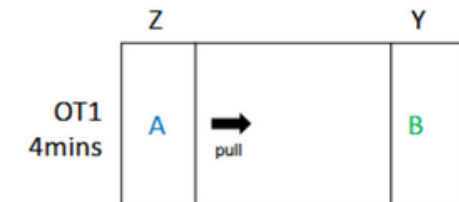
(Additional stoppage criteria during the final 2 minutes)



Last possession

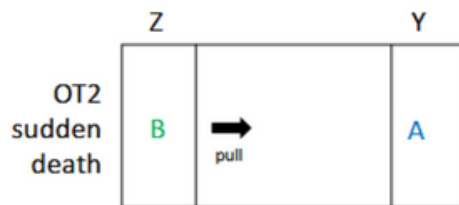
(Additional stoppage criteria during the final 2 minutes)

Coin flip.



Last possession

(Additional stoppage criteria during the final 2 minutes)



First to score wins